

Levi Tiechtel
Champaign Illinois
Lag B'omer
Bar Mitzvah Speech

Dear family and friends,

It is amazing to be standing here and welcoming you from this podium today.

As you may notice, much work and preparation has gone in to today.

It did not start a year ago with reservations and negotiations for a caterere and hall.

It did not start with the formal bar mitzvah lessons that I was privileged to have the last few months with one of my camp counselors.

It is not a Greek 'hazong', or simply a 'passage of rights. '

Today and preparations for today began 13 years and 6 days ago.

My mother tells me that she used to wake me up with a smile and a kisss every morning from birth.

My bubby's immediately and continuously showered me with endless love and gifts.

And my father would always make sure my mind and heart were directed upward and forward.

During the week his main concern and preoccupation was that I receive the same opportunity he had to learn the words of the Torah.

Coming to Champaign on our own, this was not an easy task.

My aleph bet began with my mother and continued with individual study with my father. My parents invested much time and effort afterwards to connect and establish online study from my home, and to make time with friends living and learning similarly.

My favorite Sunday mornings are of broadcasting a Jewish radio show together with my father.

Afterwards I would spend the day sharing the Judaism I learned from my mother, with local Champaign friends in our Hebrew school.

Over the years, I've learned various lessons and talents from our many community members and university students. I took violin lessons, math lessons, beatboxing lessons, and of course how to play many sports. One of my favorite sports is baseball.

Baseball and bar mitzvahs actually have a very strong connection.

A boy came to the Rebbe before his bar mitzvah to ask for his blessing. The Rebbe asked him what his favorite sport was, and the boy answered 'baseball'.

Every aspect of our life is a lesson in Judaism, how much more so an aspect wherein lies a passion.

Do you want to know what one can learn from baseball, the Rebbe asked.

Baseball games are comprised of players and fans. Players are active and play the game. Fans actively watch and provide support.

Yet what happens when in the ninth inning, it is clear that the home team is losing. What happens?

The fans stop their support and simply leave.

Yet the players stay. The players are always there, no matter what, and they are always an active part and keep their morale.

Until now, the Rebbe explained, you may have been a spectator – watching. Yet now you become a PLaYER. And a player always stays.

I am fortunate to be a player on the most wonderful team working towards some of the greatest things.

The Jewish people have been a part in almost every great development in the world. Being surrounded by so many Jewish college students, I hear much of worldly and intellectual contributions the Jewish people make.

Yet now IXZ XZ 'd like to speak about an inner development – the aspect of the Jewish soul.

Just as a body begins small and with healthy nurturing grows and becomes strong, so is a Jewish soul.

That is why preparations truly begin from the start –

The more it is nurtured, the stronger the soul can develop.

A Jewish soul is literally a part and aspect of G-d – of the one above. There is an element of holiness within that can connect, transform and reveal holiness in every aspect of this world.

At the age of bar mitzvah, the Jewish soul more fully enters the body and opens the opportunity for emotional and spiritual development and maturity.

I am privileged to have joined the ranks and to have received this opportunity.

Since my bar mitzvah day, and a few months before that, I begin every day with some time for connection and introspection.

The tehfillin bind and direct one's heart and mind above and also outward. The work of our heart and hands are holy and special when they are an expression from a solid, strongly developing and holy inner source.

It is our source of Jewish strength and security.

So many times, when Jewish lives in the holy land of Israel were jeopardized –

The Rebbe encouraged stronger physical forces and defense.

And yet, he always emphasized – fortify your spiritual defenses as well –

And then ‘chitas elokim’ – the fear of G-d – will fall upon those who wish to cause harm,

And you yourself will always be strong.

On this special day, I’d like to wish a l’chaim, and a thank you to all.

I would like to thank my parents for all of the thought and effort they put into every aspect of my upbringing, for always being there and being so supportive in so many ways.

I’d like to give a very big thank you to my great grandparents, grandparents and so much extended family who have made great effort to be here today and celebrate.

Thank you to the friends, cousins and classmates who traveled took the time and effort to travel from out of town. We spend a lot of time playing and studying over the phone and computer and it is amazing to have you in person here today.

I would like to thank my teacher for coming from Buffalo Grove, my bar mitzvah tutor Mendel Gurkow for coming New York, and camp head counselor moshe Sassonkin, and Zushe Rivkin for coming from New York as well.

I’d like to thank my siblings for being the best and most fun siblings to play with, nudge one another and sometimes argue with, but most importantly just fr being the best!

And I’d like to thank each and every one of YOU!

The simcha – the joy of today – is true and great – and such a strong source of joy must lead express itself to a concrete action.

I would be privileged and thrilled if you can join my father and I tomorrow at Chabad, and I will be happy to hel ypou put on tefillin.

And most importantly – I would like to ask you to join in the simcha today –

Please join me on the dance floor as we celebrate with pure Jewish joy!

I will be on one side with my father, friends, all of the men and all of the up and coming bar mitzvah boys –

And I would like to invite the women to please join my mother, bubby's sisters aunts and friends on the women's dance floor as well.

Simcha – Jewish joy – can overcome challenges and can bond and express our privilege to be here and celebrate this day –

Shehechyanu v'kiyemanu v'higianu lazman hazeh – l'chaim!!!!